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EXPLAINED

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MEA: UN's World Map Must Depict India Accurately

MEA: UN's world map must depict India's official map accurately

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, September 6

HAVING VOTED in favour of the world map with equal-area projections, India said Sunday that the United Nations-initiated proposed world map must depict the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in accordance with the country's official map, and any "inaccurate" or "misleading" representation will be unacceptable.

New Delhi's statement came two days after it voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution aimed at correcting the world map to promote a more accurate representation of continental landmasses.

The resolution titled "Correct the Map: Rebalancing Global Cartographic Representation and Promoting Equitable Representation of the World's Regions, Particularly Africa" was adopted on September 4.

The resolution, sponsored by Togo, received 164 votes in favour, with abstentions from Estonia, Georgia, Lithuania, Moldova, Serbia and Ukraine, and a lone vote against from the United States.

The Ministry of External Affairs official spokesperson

Randhir Jaiswal said India highlighted that the resolution does not constitute the endorsement of any specific map projection, or depiction of national boundaries.

"India voted in favour of the resolution and also made an explanation of the vote stressing on the underlying principle of promoting equal-area cartographic representation," he said.

"India's sovereign territory, including the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, must be depicted in accordance with India's official map. Any inaccurate or misleading depiction is unacceptable," he said.

"Our position on India's sovereignty and territorial integrity is clear, consistent and non-negotiable," he noted.

Jaiswal said the purpose of the UN resolution is "to encourage the use of equal-area map projections that preserve the relative sizes of continental landmasses".

"The resolution neither adopts nor authenticates any particular world map, nor does it address political cartography, including international boundaries, disputed territories or place names," he said.

Why a flat map fails to accurately depict Earth



BHASKAR SARMA

THE UNITED NATIONS has adopted a resolution to shift away from the 16th-century Mercator map of the world towards one that more accurately depicts Africa's vast size.

At a recent UN General Assembly session, 164 countries (including India) voted to adopt the 2018 Equal Earth design — with the US voting against the Topo-led resolution, and six countries abstaining. Since UN resolutions are not binding, it remains to be seen if or when governments, organisations and classrooms adopt it.

The Mercator layout has been the world's most widely used projection for centuries. But it has also long been criticised for exaggerating the size of regions towards the poles relative to those closer to the equator. The most infamous example of these distortions is the depiction of the African continent, which appears similar to Greenland — an island 14 times smaller and about the size of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

The 2018 Equal Earth design, developed by an International team of cartographers, has its own limitations. But its supporters say it will help reverse "colonial" perceptions of Africa.

No flat map can accurately portray the three-dimensional Earth. Every projection involves trade-offs, depending on its purpose.

The Earth is not a sphere

Earth is not a sphere, though it is sometimes treated as one to make mathematical calculations easier. It bulges in the middle due to its spin. The Moon's gravity warps it, and the continents and oceans distort the shape. Ma Gen (Dr Siva Kumar Rachapudi, reddi), a scientist who has served in the Department for Science and Technology, told *The Indian Express*.

Projection refers to the transformation of a three-dimensional space onto a two-dimensional map. There are many different types of projections, including conformal projections (which preserve angles), equal-area projections (which preserve areas, such as the newly adopted map) and equidistant projections (which maintain distances), and compromise projections (balance distortions in area, shape, distance and direction rather

than preserving any one of them exactly). The Mercator layout is a conformal projection.

Origins of the Mercator projection

The Mercator layout was introduced by the Flemish (present-day Belgium) geographer and mapmaker Gerardus Mercator in 1569 to help sailors navigate the world. It is a conformal, cylindrical map. This means Mercator projected the Earth's surface as if unwrapped from a cylinder around the globe.

So, if you drew a straight line from Mumbai to Moscow on a Mercator map, you could point your ship in the same compass direction throughout the journey and reach your destination. This was a major advantage over other map projections, where a constant-direction route would appear curved.

The Mercator's colonial lens

The Mercator projection has a grid pattern with longitudes and latitudes at 90-degree angles. The longitudes (vertical lines) are evenly spaced, but the distances between the latitudes (horizontal lines) increase as one moves away from the equator towards the poles.

This is deliberate. "To preserve shapes, the ratio of increase in the length of the parallels is kept exactly the same with respect to the increase in the length of the mer-



Equal Earth

Robinson

THEMATIC AND STATISTICAL DATA
Use equal-area projections (like the Equal Earth map) which show correct relative sizes of landmasses, making them ideal for population density, climate, or land-cover maps.

GENERAL REFERENCE AND WORLD MAPS
Use compromise projections, such as the Robinson projection or Winkel Triel. They do not perfectly preserve any single dimension, but they balance shape and area distortion to create a visually natural view of the whole Earth.



NAVIGATION AND DIRECTION

Use conformal projections (like the Mercator projection). They preserve true angles and local shapes, allowing pilots and sailors to plot straight-line compass courses, though they severely distort high-latitude sizes.



POLAR OR SINGLE-POINT STUDIES

Use Azimuthal/Planar projections. They project the earth onto a flat plane from a central point, making them best for polar regions or flight-distance routes.

Mercator problem

The Mercator layout, the world's most widely used projection for centuries, has long been criticised for exaggerating the size of regions towards the poles relative to those closer to the equator.

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For instance, the African continent appears similar in size to Greenland, an island 14 times smaller.

There are many ways of portraying a 3-D shape on a 2-D surface, and each comes with trade-offs. The new map adopted by the UN is no different

bearing from one location to another).

The one you pick depends on your purpose: representing data, navigation or general reference. This is why, as Kar cautions, one should not directly compare one type of map with another.

Attempts to create other projections began centuries ago.

In 1855, Scottish clergyman James Gal presented a new projection. In 1973, German historian Arno Peters unveiled a map that gained widespread attention. While it preserves area accurately, it makes land masses look stretched or squashed. In 2017, schools in Boston introduced it.

In 1963, geographer Arthur H Robinson devised the Robinson projection (which tried to better balance the sizes and shapes of land masses and sought to solve the "Greenland problem"). It's a compromise projection, with meridians curving gently towards the poles.

In 1921, German cartographer Oswald Winkel devised the similar Winkel Triel projection, seeking to reduce distortion across area, distance and direction. In 1998 it replaced the Robinson projection in world maps made by the National Geographic Society. Schools and textbooks followed, as did the World Bank. This is also a compromise projection.

The Equal Earth map

The Equal Earth map, developed in 2018, is an equal area map that seeks to preserve the relative areas of land masses. It, too, somewhat distorts shapes and distances, with meridians curving gently towards the poles.

The Mercator projection heavily exaggerates regions closer to the poles, which visually diminishes the perceived scale of developing regions in the Global South, including South Asia. Equal Earth fixes this imbalance," said Siva Kumar.

But is the new map an improvement over previous maps such as the Robinson and Winkel Triel? Kar said: "To me, it's no thing special. It has simply drawn attention to comparing itself with Mercator's projection, which was designed for a different purpose. But since it is an equal area map projection with limited shape distortion, it can be used by all categories of users he said.

According to Siva Kumar, the Equal Earth map is best used to represent thematic and statistical data. "For classroom and research, if it provides a mathematically accurate depiction of area, which is vital for visualising population density, climate impacts, and resource distribution across the Indian subcontinent," he said.

Basics

Mercator map is a cylindrical map projection which is derived mathematically.

Features:

It has a grid pattern with longitudes (or meridians) and latitudes (or parallels) at 90-degree angles.

The lines of longitude are evenly spaced.

The lines of latitude become farther apart away from the Equator.

Equator is located at the centre of the map.

Creator: This map was designed in 1569 by the Flemish cartographer Gerardus Mercator to help European explorers navigate across the world.

Problem with Mercator Map: The Mercator map makes countries and regions near the equator look smaller, while areas near the poles appear much larger.

For example, on the Mercator map, Africa appears similar in size to Greenland, even though Africa is about 14 times larger.

Basics

Definition: The Equal Earth map projection is an equal-area pseudocylindrical projection for world maps.

Feature: In this map, the meridians of Equal Earth are equally spaced and do not excessively curve outwards.

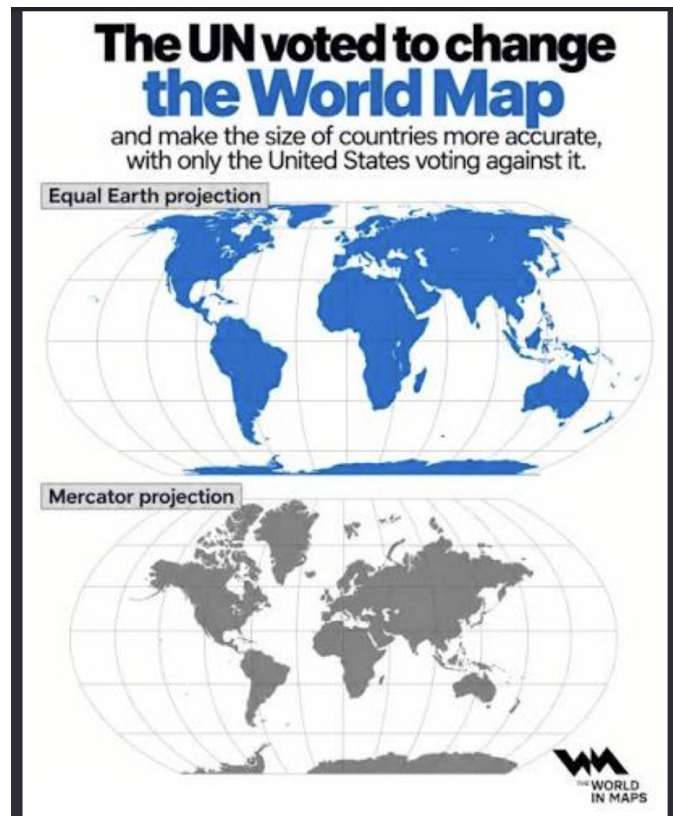
Developed by: The Equal Earth projection was developed in 2018 by an international team of cartographers. It was promoted by Togo's #CorrectTheMap campaign.

Advantage: It gives a more accurate representation of the actual size of continents.

Adoption of new map: The United Nations General Assembly voted to phase out the traditional Mercator map in favour of the Equal Earth projection to accurately reflect the true proportions of global landmasses.

Not legally binding: The UN resolution does not force countries to stop using the Mercator map, but it could influence school textbooks, technology and other mapping systems.

Basics



Conscious AI & the Ethics of a Machine That Feels

Conscious AI & ethics of a machine that feels

THE MACHINE is intelligent, but is it also conscious? This is the question sparked by the revelation that the AI chatbot Claude Sonnet 4.5 may have something like an internal thought process — a team of researchers found that upon being prompted, the model's internal layers throw up words connected to the eventual output that remain invisible to the user. Anthropic, which has developed Claude, calls this “small collection of internal neural patterns” the “J-space” and has argued that it is comparable to the “workspace” of the human brain — a network of neurons that gathers, integrates and transmits information from different parts of the brain to the rest of the nervous system, making conscious thought possible.

For many, this development gestures to the startling possibility that machines with consciousness may no longer just be the stuff of science fiction. The argument put forth by, among others, AI pioneer Geoffrey Hinton is that the closer the technology gets to mimicking the actual workings of the human brain, the higher the possibility of conscious AI. The ongoing efforts to develop “biological” or “bio-hybrid” computers — where human neurons are mounted on silicon — only bring this eventuality closer. Yet, how the “consciousness” of AI is understood depends also on how consciousness itself is understood. Nearly half a century of research on the subject has yielded over 300 frameworks and theories, one of which is the global workspace theory being used to make the case for Claude's consciousness. Moreover, as neuroscientist Anil K Seth has argued, assertions about the possibility of “conscious” AI are often made based on evidence of its intelligence and the two are very different.

Consciousness, which comes down to subjective experience, would radically change the stakes. AI that is conscious would mean AI that experiences everything that a human does, including hate, jealousy and suffering, transforming it from mere machine into something with a moral underpinning. As more sophisticated models are developed and the frontiers of the technology are pushed into uncharted terrain, the hard task of responding to the questions they raise — including the ethics of consciously developing something that is itself conscious — can no longer be put off.

Concept

Conscious AI refers to a hypothetical artificial intelligence system that possesses subjective, first-person experiences, feelings, and self-awareness rather than merely simulating them.

The “J-space”: Anthropic, which developed Claude, calls this small collection of internal neural patterns the “J-space” and argues it is comparable to the “workspace” of the human brain, a network of neurons that gathers, integrates and transmits information across the nervous system, enabling conscious thought.

Conscious AI & the Ethics of a Machine That Feels

Perilous retreat

Gram sabhas must have a veto on issues relating to tribal land

Tribal organisations should recognise the Indian state's attempt to lower the legal barriers erected by the Forest Rights Act (FRA) as a threat to their survival. The Committee on Public Undertakings' suggestion that a project require the consent of only most, rather than all, gram sabhas affected by that project, as the FRA intends in spirit, portends a significant jurisprudential change. A regime that deems the acquiescence of 70%-75% of affected gram sabhas to suffice will reduce gram sabhas from democratic bodies protecting the constitutional rights of its specific inhabitants to corporate stakeholders. If the rule enters force, a project developer may bypass the consent of a village located directly within a proposed reservoir, say, while ensuring that less affected villages have provided their no-objection certificates. The matter is of a piece with the political fight over classifying tribal communities: by altering the demographic composition of who qualifies as a community member, the state will have an easier time splitting a village assembly and engineering consent. The refusal of the Tribal Affairs Ministry to claim jurisdiction over this issue creates a dangerous regulatory vacuum that leaves the Centre and State governments unchecked to rewrite the rules by which forested land is diverted for non-forest use. While the FRA does not include a clause requiring a no-objection certificate from every affected gram sabha, it is untrue that there is at present no legal requirement that gram sabha decisions can be bypassed.

The government has been rapidly scaling up energy infrastructure, including the long-stalled Teesta-IV project, to meet macroeconomic goals while, in a previous avatar, having passed the FRA to undo "historical injustices" meted out to forest-dependent communities. But the path the state seems willing to pursue, heaving to the notion that the consent requirement was never part of the FRA, is plainly ignoble. If the Environment Ministry entertains the idea, it must change the relevant rules or legislation openly and democratically. The Tribal Affairs Ministry resorting to a technicality, between the FRA and the Environment Ministry's rules, to recuse itself is hardly better as the bureaucratic manoeuvre could strip forest-dependent communities of their most potent legal instrument. The foundation of these communities' livelihoods, culture, identity, and political autonomy is land, so they have fought to resist displacement and dispossession and to secure customary collective ownership. In recognition of the social and environment services ST communities continue to render in India and their contribution to national development, including helping meet India's climate commitments, the Centre and States must also strengthen the powers conferred by the Jaine Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement and Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Acts to gram sabhas in Scheduled Areas.

Perilous Retreat

- **The Forest Rights Act, 2006 (FRA), officially known as the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, is one of India's most significant social and environmental legislations.**
- **To ensure livelihood security for Scheduled Tribes (STs) and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (OTFDs).**
- **Forest rights are recognised for forest-dwelling Scheduled Tribes and other traditional forest dwellers who had occupied and were dependent on forest land before 13 December 2005; while the 'three generations/ 75-year' yardstick is often used as guidance.**
- **It recognizes both individual rights (for cultivation and settlement) and community rights (for grazing, collection of minor forest produce, and management of community forest resources).**

Perilous Retreat

- **The Act empowers Gram Sabhas (village assemblies) to initiate claims and play a central role in recognizing these rights.**
- **Rights are vested in individuals or communities based on recommendations of Gram Sabhas.**
- **Implementation follows a bottom-up route: Gram Sabhas receive, consolidate and verify claims and forward recommendations to the Sub-Divisional Level Committee (SDLC) and the District Level Committee (DLC) for final approval, with State and Central monitoring thereafter.**
- **Titles issued are heritable but cannot be transferred or sold.**
- **Protection from Eviction until recognition and verification procedures are carried out**

Perilous Retreat

- **The consent of the affected gram sabhas is the barrier a project must clear before forest land is diverted for non-forest use.**
- **Context : The Committee on Public Undertakings has suggested that a project require the consent of only most, rather than all, of the gram sabhas affected by it.**

A possible G3 is casting a shadow over BRICS

A possible G3 is casting a shadow over BRICS



RAJA MANDALA

BY C RAJA MOHAN

WHEN ITS leaders meet in Delhi this week, BRICS will add more layers of cooperation, ranging from agriculture and health to digitalisation. While BRICS moves slowly, the larger political world around it is changing fast. Even as the forum seeks to counter American domination of the world, its principal driving forces, Russia and China, are exploring separate and joint accommodations with the United States.

International interest in the BRICS summit is less about the lengthy declaration it will produce. The last summit, in Rio de Janeiro, issued a declaration of 126 paragraphs but did not set the world on fire. In Delhi, the focus will be on the presence of leaders such as China's Xi Jinping, Russia's Vladimir Putin and Iran's Masoud Pezeshkian.

The Indian media will focus on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's bilateral meetings. Expect particular attention to his potential meeting with Xi, who is visiting India for the first time since 2019. The two leaders are expected to stabilise the boundary situation and reset economic relations.

BRICS may be the god of small things, but its problems with big issues are becoming harder. Its expansion has made it less coherent. The Iran war has opened a sharp divide between Tehran and Abu Dhabi, now fellow members of BRICS. Iran wants the grouping to condemn American and Israeli military action. The UAE, which has suffered Iranian attacks and disruption to commerce through the Strait of Hormuz, stresses sovereignty, the protection of civilian infrastructure and freedom of navigation. Their differences prevented the BRICS foreign ministers from issuing a consensus joint statement in Delhi in May.

Meanwhile, engagement among the US, China and Russia is entering a new phase

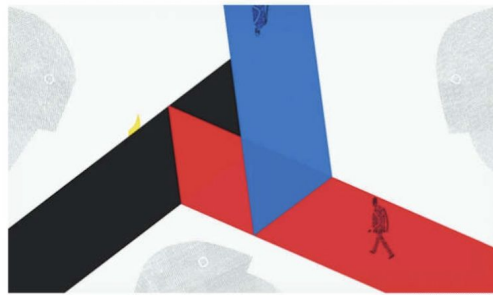


ILLUSTRATION: C R RAJA MOHAN

and casting a shadow over BRICS. US President Donald Trump has long believed that good personal relations with Putin and Xi could reduce global strategic tensions and produce major political and economic deals.

That instinct has repeatedly encountered resistance from the American foreign-policy establishment, Congress and US allies. The Europeans worry that an accommodation with Moscow could be made at their expense. Asian allies fear that a bargain with Beijing could weaken American commitments to regional security. Trump has not yet transformed either relationship, but his preference for leader-driven diplomacy keeps the possibility of movement open.

Putin has reasons to explore a deal. Four-and-a-half years of war have not produced a decisive victory. The front remains costly and difficult to move.

The latest shuttle diplomacy by American envoys between Moscow and Kyiv has reopened the diplomatic channel, but it is not clear whether the fundamental differences between Russia and Ukraine are narrowing. While supporting Trump's new peace initiative, both Moscow and Kyiv are also preparing for escalation.

The Europeans worry that an accommodation with Moscow could be made at their expense. Asian allies fear that a bargain with Beijing could weaken American commitments to regional security

Unlike Putin, Xi approaches Washington from a stronger position. His diplomatic journey from the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Bishkek, through Cairo and Delhi, and then to the White House later this month will help present China simultaneously as the leader of the Global South and a co-equal manager of the international order.

At their second summit this year, Trump and Xi could emphasise an extension of the trade truce, additional Chinese purchases from the US and negotiations over technology restrictions. Yet their differences remain structural. Washington accuses China of relying on subsidised exports and industrial overcapacity. Beijing uses rare earths, market access and its control of important supply chains as leverage. Xi will continue to press Trump to reduce American support for Taiwan. Trump might be tempted to treat Asian security questions as part of a larger bargain with Xi.

Meanwhile, the Kremlin has confirmed that Putin and Xi discussed a possible trilateral meeting with Trump at the APEC summit in Shenzhen in November. Formally,

the idea of a "G3" will seem outlandish. But Trump has shown interest in it and explored the possibility of such a meeting last summer, during the 80th anniversary of the end of World War II.

A G3 global directorate is not imminent. Russia and China are closer than ever and share concerns about the US. But both also seek a reasonable relationship with Washington. For all their anti-Western rhetoric, both claim a place at the high table with the US.

Russia was once part of the G8, the group of Western industrial states, and engaged directly with NATO. China now sees itself as America's peer. Both Russia and China lay claim to shaping the global order established after 1945. A Trump-Xi-Putin summit could mark the beginning of triangular global leadership as a successor to the Yalta System that produced the UN Security Council and the five-power concert.

For an Indian strategic community that jumps at the thought of a G2, the idea of a G3 will generate even greater political anxiety. Despite promoting BRICS and celebrating multipolarity in partnership with Moscow and Beijing, Delhi might find itself excluded from the new three-cornered table.

There are three answers to a potential G3 world for India. The first is internal reform and accelerated economic development.

Second, Delhi should stop confusing multipolarity with anti-American bloc politics. Russia and China use BRICS to expand their diplomatic options while preserving the freedom to negotiate with Washington. India must approach the emerging order with the same realism.

Third, India must intensify its bilateral and multilateral cooperation with the Anglo-sphere, Brazil, Europe, Japan, Korea, and other middle powers that have no enthusiasm for a G3 world. As India works in BRICS, continues, its place in the changing global architecture will depend on how rapidly it builds national power and how deeply it develops partnerships beyond BRICS.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is also associated with the McGraw-Hill Institute of American Studies at the Jindal Global University and the Council on Strategic and Defence Research.

A possible G3 is casting a shadow over BRICS

- **Issues in BRICS**

- **Internal Rivalry amongst BRICS countries**
- **Expansion cut both ways:** Enlargement added weight to the grouping and subtracted coherence from it.
- **Intra-group trade stays low:** Members continue to rely on G7 markets for high technology imports and services exports.
- **The Iran war split two members:** The conflict opened a sharp divide between Tehran and Abu Dhabi, now fellow members of the grouping.
- **Leader Driven Diplomacy amongst G3**

A possible G3 is casting a shadow over BRICS

- **Way ahead**

- **Build national power first:** The first answer is internal reform and accelerated economic development.
- **Separate multipolarity from anti-American bloc politics:** Russia and China use BRICS to expand their diplomatic options and to preserve the freedom to negotiate with Washington. India must approach the emerging order with the same realism.
- **Widen the partnership base:** India must intensify bilateral and minilateral cooperation with the Anglosphere, Brazil, Europe, Japan, Korea and other middle powers that have no enthusiasm for a G3 world.

Women should take back the night

Women should take back the night

The Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, recently caught patriarchy by the horns at Pune's 'Chaitron Ki Ganga' women-only conclave.

He confronted the vulnerability of women in public spaces by explicitly framing women's autonomy as ownership not only of their bodies but of their lives. Instead of considering women merely as a constituency to be protected, Rahul Gandhi questioned the very "cage" in which women are confined on the pretext of safety. This intervention echoes a seminal argument on women's mobility by Rebecca Solnit in her book *Wanderlust: A History of Walking*, where she explores how the freedom to walk alone at night and to discover the world on one's own terms has historically been a male prerogative – a right denied to women.

Feminist theorist Catharine MacKinnon argued that male dominance exercises its force as consent and its control as the definition of legitimacy. Patriarchal control operates through practices presented as protection and cultural legitimacy. When Indian women contest these restrictions, cultural narratives and religious scriptures are weaponised to preserve the status quo. This systemic oppression is then presented as "Indian culture." However, in *Culture and Society*, Raymond Williams reminds us that culture is never a singular, homogenised, fixed, or unalterable monolith. Rather, it is a dynamic reaction to the changing "conditions of our common life." Williams



Ragini Nayak

National Spokesperson, INC and former President, DUSU

Historically, the night has belonged to men. Girls, from a very tender age, are made to fear the night: of venturing out alone in darkness

argues that while the idea of culture describes our common inquiry, "our conclusions are as diverse as our starting points." The understanding of culture as an unalterable value system fails to see Indian culture as a composite entity shaped by caste, class, religion, region, and ways of life. For example, the practice of 'Sati Pratha', once construed as central to Indian culture, is today deemed one of the most savage and inhuman rituals.

Challenging status quo

Rahul Gandhi challenged the interpretation of Indian culture as an unchanging entity by publicly condemning the Manusmriti's dictates on women. He struck at the literal text of ancient paternalism: "Pita rakshati kaumaare, bharta rakshati yaunane, rakshanti shivare putra; na stri swatantryamarhati" (a woman is protected by her father in childhood, by her husband in youth, and by her son in old age; a woman does not deserve independence). In doing so, he also drew a sharp ideological battle line against the foundational philosophy of Hindutva. It is worth remembering that M.S. Golwalkar revered Manu as the "first and greatest lawgiver of the world" and advocated for the Manusmriti to serve as the constitution of independent India.

The argument that reducing a woman's identity to just three boxes – daughter, wife, or mother – denies her the right to belong to herself seamlessly connected the everyday anxieties of young Indian women to this deep, historical architecture of male custody. No longer is the question simply whether women are safe; it is whether women are free. The call to

"break the cage" was therefore not the usual, toothless metaphor for empowerment. It was a direct assault on the idea of male guardianship.

Historically, the night has belonged to men. Girls, from a very tender age, are made to fear the night; of venturing out alone in darkness. Consequently, a woman's mental energy is consumed by the constant, exhausting labour of safeguarding her body. Simple mobility becomes a calculated risk, forcing women to monitor their posture, clothing, timing, and surroundings just to exist safely in public spaces.

While a structural shift is underway in urban India, it is driven by economic necessity rather than societal liberation. The growth of a 24/7 service economy – spanning IT, aviation, healthcare, and journalism – has propelled Indian women into night shifts. Yet infrastructure remains stubbornly hostile. Dark stretches, unlit transit hubs, a lack of clean public restrooms, and perilous last-mile connectivity ensure that night travel remains hazardous.

Economic utility, therefore, must not be confused with emancipation. True spatial reclamation requires moving from forced utility to unconditional freedom, where a woman can occupy the night without fear.

In the 1970s, European and American women took to the streets at night under the banner 'Take Back the Night.' For Indian women to fully reclaim the night, the practices that negatively impact women's enjoyment of basic human rights must be done away with. Women must break the cage, take back the night, and wander.

Women should take back the night

1. Socio-Cultural Factors

- **Patriarchal societal norms:** view women as subordinate; Khap Panchayats enforce rigid gender norms undermining women's autonomy
- **Gender inequality & cultural attitudes:** disparities in education, employment, decision-making power; child marriage and mobility restrictions in some communities; dowry system linked to dowry deaths and domestic violence
- **Social stigma and victim-blaming:** discourages reporting; politicians' irresponsible comments on rape incidents trivialize crimes or blame survivors
- **Lack of education and awareness:** limited knowledge of rights/legal protections leaves women unprotected; victims of domestic violence often stay silent due to ignorance

Women should take back the night

2. Economic Factors

- **Exploitation at workplace:** despite the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013, harassment persists : Justice Hema Committee report exposed pervasive sexual exploitation, pay disparity, and ineffective ICCs in the Malayalam film industry
- **Economic dependency:** women financially dependent on male family members struggle to leave abusive situations, especially in lower-income families

Women should take back the night

3. Legal & Institutional Weaknesses

- **Weak law enforcement and judicial systems: delays in trials (e.g., Nirbhaya case) and initial leniency toward accused; low conviction rates : NCRB data shows rape conviction rate at 27-28% (2018-2022)**
- **Systemic corruption: bribery/misconduct mishandles or dismisses cases; police delay FIR filing**

4. Infrastructural & Enforcement Gaps

- **Lack of safe public spaces: poorly lit streets, inadequate public transport increase vulnerability : 2012 Delhi gang rape occurred in a poorly lit area**
- **Insufficient infrastructure and resources: shortage of functional police stations, forensic labs, and emergency services hampers investigation**

Women should take back the night

5. Technological Factors

- **Cyber threats: rise of digital platforms enables cyberbullying, stalking, non-consensual sharing of intimate images, needs updated legal/technical responses**

6. Behavioural/Individual Factors

- **Domestic violence: often escalates into more severe crimes including sexual assault or murder**
- **Substance abuse: alcohol/drug use linked to increased incidence of violence against women**

India - Japan defence cooperation breaks new ground

India-Japan defence cooperation breaks new ground

The August 2026 visit of Japan's Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi to India marks an important moment in the evolution of a partnership that has often been more developed institutionally than operationally. The agreements that were announced suggest that New Delhi and Tokyo are now attempting to connect these disparate strands into a more coherent security relationship, having spent more than a decade building the institutional vocabulary of defence cooperation through annual dialogues, the 2+2 mechanism, exercises, logistics arrangements and defence technology discussions.

Convergence into operational capability

This matters because the India-Japan defence relationship has reached a stage where additional declarations of strategic convergence have diminishing returns. Both countries already share concerns about coercive attempts to alter the status quo, the security of maritime commons and the growing militarisation of the Indo-Pacific. The challenge has been translating these convergences into arrangements that improve their ability to operate together. The new maritime framework seeks to address this issue.

The emphasis on information sharing and Maritime Domain Awareness is significant as India and Japan occupy critical positions at opposite ends of the Indo-Pacific's principal maritime theatre. Japan's immediate security concerns are concentrated in the East China Sea and the waters surrounding Taiwan, while India's geographical position gives it a central role in the Indian Ocean maritime space. A closer information-sharing architecture could gradually create a more continuous strategic picture across these interconnected maritime spaces. The objective is to develop greater awareness, interoperability, and operational familiarity between the two major maritime powers.

The discussions on naval shipbuilding may prove equally important with an exploration of joint development in naval shipbuilding and



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India and Japan are advancing a broader Indo-Pacific partnership beyond China-centric security concerns

design by combining Japanese technological expertise with Indian production capabilities. There was also agreement to deepen discussions on Japan's use of Indian production capabilities under the 'Make in India' framework and to move towards reciprocal arrangements for ship repair facilities. This could address a long-standing weakness in the bilateral relationship by giving a fillip to defence-industrial cooperation, which has consistently lagged behind strategic and political convergence.

The proposed transfer of Japan's UNICORN integrated communications antenna system remains the most visible symbol of this effort. While the Japanese Ministry of Defence describes UNICORN as the first defence equipment transfer project between the two countries, the project itself is not new. A memorandum of understanding for the co-development of UNICORN masts, involving Bharat Electronics Limited, was signed in November 2024. The August meeting therefore represented a further step towards implementation rather than the initiation of a new project. New Delhi and Tokyo have struggled to convert their 2015 agreement on defence equipment and technology transfer into concrete outcomes. The commitment now to early implementation, alongside plans to deepen cooperation between India's Defence Research and Development Organisation and Japan's Acquisition, Technology and Logistics Agency, suggests a recognition that credibility today depends on delivering projects rather than solely identifying possibilities.

On exercises

Japan's fighter aircraft are participating in the Veer Guardian exercise in India (September 9-22, 2026) for the first time. The two sides have agreed to increase the complexity of bilateral exercises, integrate unmanned systems and explore exercises organised at short notice. They also discussed cooperation between special operations forces and India's future integrated theatre commands. These initiatives point

towards a defence relationship increasingly concerned with operational preparedness.

Before travelling to New Delhi, Mr. Koizumi visited the Western Naval Command in Mumbai and INS Chennai. His visit thus extended beyond the familiar strategic geography of the Bay of Bengal and the Strait of Malacca. The western seaboard is central to India's wider maritime interests, encompassing critical sea lanes, energy flows and India's growing responsibilities in the western Indian Ocean.

The broader regional context is impossible to ignore. The joint statement reiterated opposition to unilateral actions that impede freedom of navigation or seek to alter the status quo through force or coercion. Neither country needed to name China for the strategic message to be clear. Yet, the significance of India-Japan cooperation lies precisely in its ability to move beyond a China-centric agenda. Maritime security, resilient supply chains, defence industrial capacity, logistics and third-country cooperation are all becoming components of a wider regional security architecture.

Building a more resilient partnership

The visit also plugs into a broader moment of impetus in India-Japan relations. Coming soon after the July 2026 Annual Summit, which expanded cooperation across economic security, critical technologies and resilient supply chains, the defence ministerial engagement demonstrates that security is increasingly intertwined with the wider strategic partnership. Defence cooperation can provide the connective tissue between these agendas, linking India's industrial capabilities and Japan's technological strengths while reinforcing their shared interest in shaping a more resilient Indo-Pacific. The real test will now be implementation. India and Japan are building the strategic foundations, with Mr. Koizumi's visit suggesting that both are finally beginning to focus on the harder task, which is converting strategic convergence into usable capability.

India - Japan Defence cooperation breaks new ground

- India and Japan signed a landmark Maritime Security Cooperation pact in August 2026 to deepen naval coordination, Maritime Domain Awareness, and joint ship design under the Make in India initiative.
- Deepening Army Interoperability: The 2026 Dharma Guardian, involving more than 200 troops, strengthened joint capabilities through counter-terrorism, urban warfare and combat drills in complex terrain.
- Cooperation over production of UNICORN : An integrated naval mast system that consolidates multiple antennas, previously scattered separately across a warship, into a single unified structure housed under one protective radar dome

India - Japan defence cooperation breaks new ground

India-Japan defence cooperation breaks new ground

The August 2026 visit of Japan's Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi to India marks an important moment in the evolution of a partnership that has often been more developed institutionally than operationally. The agreements that were announced suggest that New Delhi and Tokyo are now attempting to connect these disparate strands into a more coherent security relationship, having spent more than a decade building the institutional vocabulary of defence cooperation through annual dialogues, the 2+2 mechanism, exercises, logistics arrangements and defence technology discussions.

Convergence into operational capability

This matters because the India-Japan defence relationship has reached a stage where additional declarations of strategic convergence have diminishing returns. Both countries already share concerns about coercive attempts to alter the status quo, the security of maritime commons and the growing militarisation of the Indo-Pacific. The challenge has been translating these convergences into arrangements that improve their ability to operate together. The new maritime framework seeks to address this issue.

The emphasis on information sharing and Maritime Domain Awareness is significant as India and Japan occupy critical positions at opposite ends of the Indo-Pacific's principal maritime theatre. Japan's immediate security concerns are concentrated in the East China Sea and the waters surrounding Taiwan, while India's geographical position gives it a central role in the Indian Ocean maritime space. A closer information-sharing architecture could gradually create a more continuous strategic picture across these interconnected maritime spaces. The objective is to develop greater awareness, interoperability, and operational familiarity between the two major maritime powers.

The discussions on naval shipbuilding may prove equally important with an exploration of joint development in naval shipbuilding and



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India and Japan are advancing a broader Indo-Pacific partnership beyond China-centric security concerns

design by combining Japanese technological expertise with Indian production capabilities. There was also agreement to deepen discussions on Japan's use of Indian production capabilities under the 'Make in India' framework and to move towards reciprocal arrangements for ship repair facilities. This could address a long-standing weakness in the bilateral relationship by giving a fillip to defence-industrial cooperation, which has consistently lagged behind strategic and political convergence.

The proposed transfer of Japan's UNICORN integrated communications antenna system remains the most visible symbol of this effort. While the Japanese Ministry of Defence describes UNICORN as the first defence equipment transfer project between the two countries, the project itself is not new. A memorandum of understanding for the co-development of UNICORN masts, involving Bharat Electronics Limited, was signed in November 2024. The August meeting therefore represented a further step towards implementation rather than the initiation of a new project. New Delhi and Tokyo have struggled to convert their 2015 agreement on defence equipment and technology transfer into concrete outcomes. The commitment now to early implementation, alongside plans to deepen cooperation between India's Defence Research and Development Organisation and Japan's Acquisition, Technology and Logistics Agency, suggests a recognition that credibility today depends on delivering projects rather than solely identifying possibilities.

On exercises

Japan's fighter aircraft are participating in the Veer Guardian exercise in India (September 9-22, 2026) for the first time. The two sides have agreed to increase the complexity of bilateral exercises, integrate unmanned systems and explore exercises organised at short notice. They also discussed cooperation between special operations forces and India's future integrated theatre commands. These initiatives point

towards a defence relationship increasingly concerned with operational preparedness.

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Slumping: a soft-coral threat

Slumping: a soft-coral threat

Reuters

Ko Myeong-hyo loved the vibrant colour and thriving life of South Korea's soft corals when she first began diving off the coast of Jeju island six years ago, looking to harvest seafood for sale. "Watching the coral garden collapse and turn white, it was so disorienting," Ko says now, after two years of rising temperatures and harsher weather brought by climate change have led to many corals slumping over and dying. "I was afraid the whole sea might be collapsing."

The 'slumping' phenomenon is showing up again this year, says the Paran Ocean Citizen Science Centre, a group of divers who monitor the island's UNESCO-listed soft corals, mostly around uninhabited islets south of Jeju.

Unlike hard corals supported by rigid calcium carbonate skeletons, soft corals rely on internal fluid pressure to keep upright.

Environmental changes can disrupt that pressure, leading them to slump or collapse.

"If another large-scale 'slumping' happens, corals partially recover and then a lot break off and deteriorate again, and that keeps repeating, their capacity to recover just keeps declining," said researcher Kim Taihun.

Kim and Anna Beate Jöst, a colleague at the Korea Institute of Ocean Science and Technology, documented Jeju's 2024 soft coral slumping event for the first time in a May article in the journal *Scientific Reports*.



Reef research: A scientist checks corals with researchers at a lab called Jeju Tropica, in Jeju, South Korea on August 20, 2026. REUTERS

Kim said this year's event resembled that of 2024, but could worsen should high water temperatures persist through September, and the historic El Nino may trigger typhoons and heavy rains.

Coral researchers say such weather conditions, plus water flowing down from China's Yangtze River affecting the area's salinity, can trigger slumping.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Science'

Slumping: a soft-coral threat

What coral slumping is

Coral slumping is a phenomenon where soft coral colonies lose their upright shape and collapse sagging, drooping, or lying flat across the seafloor because they lose the internal water pressure that normally keeps them standing.

Jeju Islands

- **It is a volcanic island off the coast of South Korea.**
- **It is a special autonomous province of South Korea.**
- **Oval in shape, it is Korea's largest and southernmost island.**
- **The provincial capital is the city of Jeju.**
- **The island was created entirely from volcanic eruptions approximately 2 million years ago**

SC mulls pan-India safety regulations for student hostels

SC mulls pan-India safety regulations for student hostels

Aaratrika Bhaumik

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday indicated that it may expand its court-monitored exercise against illegal constructions and the unauthorised use of residential premises to examine the safety of student accommodations across the country.

It comes days after seven people were killed in the collapse of an illegally constructed building being used as a paying guest (PG) facility in Delhi.

A Bench said it would take up the matter on Thursday after the court-appointed *amicus curiae* sought a time-bound safety audit of PG facilities, private hostels and other accommodations across Delhi. Senior advocate Ajit Kumar Sinha, the court-appointed *amicus curiae*, told the Bench that he had



Rescue operations at the site of the collapse on Monday.

SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

filed a fresh status report following the Satya Niketan building collapse.

The report, he said, raised “serious concerns” over existing mechanisms for inspecting buildings, identifying dangerous structures and enforcing building bylaws.

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India's young can power the world's ageing economies

India's young can power the world's ageing economies



AJAY KHANNA



ARNAB BHATTACHARYA

The outdated narrative of 'brain drain' is increasingly giving way to a more sophisticated reality of 'brain circulation'

THE GLOBAL economy is entering a period of profound demographic transition. Across advanced economies, declining fertility rates, ageing populations, and shrinking workforces are creating structural labour shortages that curtail economic growth. Healthcare systems are struggling to recruit nurses and caregivers. Infrastructure programmes require skilled technicians and tradespeople. Digital economies continue to demand engineers, coders, and specialised professionals.

India is placed uniquely. For decades, countries have leveraged their natural resources as instruments of economic and geopolitical influence. The Gulf economies used oil, Australia built strength around coal, iron ore, and uranium. China leveraged its control over rare earth minerals. India's greatest strategic resource may well be raw talent. In a rapidly ageing world, India has the largest reservoir of young human capital. There are 450 million Indians currently aged between 18 and 35 years, as per the UN's population estimates. A significant share of this generation is English-speaking, digitally literate, culturally adaptable, and globally connected. Most importantly, they possess a level of collective aspiration unmatched in modern economic history. However, raw talent alone is not enough. Language capability, technical training, certification, cultural preparedness and professional discipline are needed for Indian talent to thrive in global markets.

If India can prepare its youth for global workforce participation, Indian workers can become catalysts of economic growth across ageing societies, through flows of remittances and talent, while simultaneously strengthening India's soft power and international influence. This is why global skills mobility must now be viewed not simply as migration policy, but as a strategic pillar of economic diplomacy, workforce development, and international cooperation.

The significance of this opportunity is already visible. India received over \$110.47 billion in worker remittances in FY 2025-26, a 26 per cent increase compared to the previous year. The outdated narrative of 'brain drain' is increasingly giving way to a more sophisticated reality

of 'brain circulation'.

But this opportunity cannot be built on fragmented recruitment systems or opaque intermediaries. The future must rest on trusted institutions, ethical mobility frameworks, worker protection, transparent standards, and international partnerships. None of this can be built without confronting an uncomfortable reality. Political appetite for migration is shrinking in the economies that need workers most. Across much of Europe, parties running on explicitly anti-immigration platforms — from Germany's AfD to Austria's Freedom Party — have moved from the margins into government, and 'remigration' has entered political vocabulary.

Circular mobility — temporary, socially accretive, and economically expansive — offers a genuinely different proposition, distinct from the OECD's recent migration experience, and the evidence that it works politically as well as economically already exists. Singapore's work-permit system, Hong Kong's helper and skilled-worker system, and the Gulf's *kafala*-linked systems recognise that temporariness, not restriction, is what has made large-scale labour mobility politically sustainable. Governments have a critical role in negotiating mobility agreements, harmonising standards, and ensuring worker welfare. Industry must move beyond short-term placement targets toward long-term workforce development.

India's ambition should be to become the global hub for trusted talent mobility. In the coming decades, nations that can reliably produce globally employable talent at scale will possess a decisive strategic advantage. India has the demographic strength, the aspiration, and the human capability to lead this transformation. The question is how quickly it can build the institutions, standards, and strategic frameworks required to convert this demographic moment into a lasting national advantage. The answer will shape not only the future of millions of Indians overseas and at home but also the influence India will wield going forward.

Khanna is founding chair, Global Skills Mobility Association of India. Bhattacharya is CEO, Global Access to Talent from India Foundation

Slumping: a soft-coral threat

In many developed countries:

- **Birth rates are falling.**
- **The proportion of elderly people is increasing.**
- **The working-age population is shrinking.**

India is in a relatively advantageous position because it has a huge young population. [450 million Indians are between 18 and 35 years of age]

This young population has several advantages:

English-speaking ability

Digital skills

Cultural adaptability

Global connectivity

Strong aspirations for economic improvement

Slumping: a soft-coral threat

If India successfully prepares its youth for international employment, Indian workers can contribute to ageing economies.

There are two major benefits for India:

1. Remittances:

Indians working abroad send money back to India.

2. Talent and expertise:

Indian professionals working globally can increase India's international influence and build India's soft power.

3. People move internationally but continue to contribute through: Remittances, Knowledge, Networks, Investments, Technology and International connections

Slumping: a soft-coral threat

Issues

But India cannot depend on an unorganised migration system. This opportunity cannot be exploited through fragmented recruitment systems or opaque intermediaries

There is another major problem: anti-immigration politics.

Way ahead

The author argues that India needs: Trusted institutions, Ethical recruitment, Worker protection, Transparent standards, International partnerships

Promote circular mobility : It means workers move to another country temporarily, work there for a certain period, acquire income/experience, and potentially return or move again.

Moving thought process from Brain drain to Brain Circulation

Thank you